

Section 2: - Proposal to Preserve St David's Abbey Site

Carrigtwohill & District Historical Society

2.1 General Overview

2.1.1 Society Objectives

Carrigtwohill & District Historical Society (CDHS) was established by a group of local enthusiasts with a constitution adopted and signed at the AGM, 13th June 2013, with the aim of achieving the following objectives:

- 2.1 To generate a greater awareness and appreciation of our historic area, especially among the local population.
- 2.2 To preserve and protect all our remaining historical features.
- 2.3 To encourage research into and the recording of local history, archaeology, folk-life and folk lore and preserve and protect local heritage, songs, stories, photographs etc.
- 2.4 To actively promote the Carrigtwohill area as a significant tourist centre.
- 2.5 To encourage and undertake the publication of books and periodic reviews and the collection and copying of archives.
- 2.6 To build a local archive of documents (or photocopies of documents), illustrations and artefacts relating to the local history of Carrigtwohill and the surrounding area.
- 2.7 To organize historic lectures and talks by guests and members.
- 2.8 To extend any of the above and develop additional activities as opportunities arise.

As a society (CDHS) it has long seen that there is an urgent need to secure the stability of the remaining St. David's structures described in the Ordinance Survey of Ireland (OSI) maps as an 'Abbey in ruins.' So much so, and in accordance with the constitution just described, a decision was made to explore all possible avenues to secure the stability of the existing structures for future generations to admire and enjoy. This would also be in accordance with the Cork County Council's own objectives set out under two distinct categories. The HE 3-4 on Industrial and Post Medieval Archaeology, seeks to:

"Protect and preserve the archaeological value of industrial and post medieval archaeology such as mills, limekilns, bridges, piers, harbours, penal chapels and dwellings. Proposals for refurbishment, works to or redevelopment/conversion of these sites should be subject to careful assessment."

Then for their Development Plan for the period 2022-2028 adopted by the elected members of Cork County Council, 25th April 2022, which came into effect, 6th June 2022. Outline a further objective in relation to protected structures the development plan includes clause HE-16-6:

"Industrial and Post Medieval Archaeology Protect and preserve industrial and post-medieval archaeology and long-term management of heritage features such as mills, limekilns, forges, bridges, piers and harbours, water-related engineering works and buildings, penal chapels, dwellings, walls and boundaries, farm buildings, estate features, military and coastal installations. There is a general presumption for retention of these

structures and features. Proposals for appropriate redevelopment including conversion should be subject to an appropriate assessment and record by a suitably qualified specialist/s.”

2.1.2 Research into the Site’s History

Research by CDHS would indicate that the ruins are those of the Augustinian Canon Order which were allied to the same Order of Ballybeg established between, circa, 1185 and 1206.

Following the Synod of Kells in 1152, the monasteries came under the authority of the diocese, so were no longer independent of the church authorities. For the papal tax from 1291 the structures in Carrigtwohill and Kilcurfin were described as churches within the cantred of Olethan of Castlelyons, administered by the descendants of David de Barri’s family of Barryscourt.

2.1.3 Funding Applications

In 2023 Eirgrid announced and launched their phased Celtic Interconnector Community Benefit Fund to be spread over a three-year period. It was decided by our committee that we avail of this fund, and commenced the application process for phase I, 5th July 2023, which was finally submitted after many redrafts by our committee, 14th September 2023. This application consisted of three elements:

I.	Schools Project	€1,0000
II.	Book of Parish History	€26,799
III.	Abbey Ruins & Belfry	€12,750
IV.	Village Signage Programme	€1,205

For this, our constitution was further endorsed, 21st September 2023, by the committee in accordance with the requirement of the contract being administered by SECAD on behalf of Eirgrid.

Our application was approved, 18th December 2023, and was specifically allocated for the sole purpose of financing the Parish History Book, and the Village Signage elements of the application, amounting to €5,205, split over a two year period, with the first payment of 50% made immediately upon signing the contract which was electronically done the same day.

In relation to the Abbey Ruins element, a quotation was obtained from conservation specialist, Southgate Associates of South Mall, Cork City, who have an office in Middleton. Their quotation consisted of two elements as their proposal for submission to the County Council’s Community Monuments Fund (CMF) which they would make on our behalf.

1	Ground Penetrating Radar Survey (Shanarc)	€4,305
2	Southgate Professional Services	€8,445
Total:		€12,750

2.2 Architectural evidence of Abbey Ruins

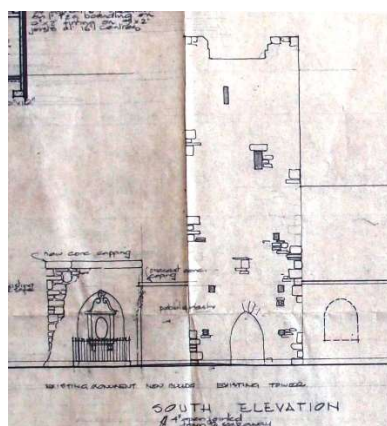
Enquiries were made to the Church of Ireland RCB Library by CDHS, seeking copies of drawings they had advised they had. These were received, 8th February 2024.

2.2.1 O'Flynn Architects

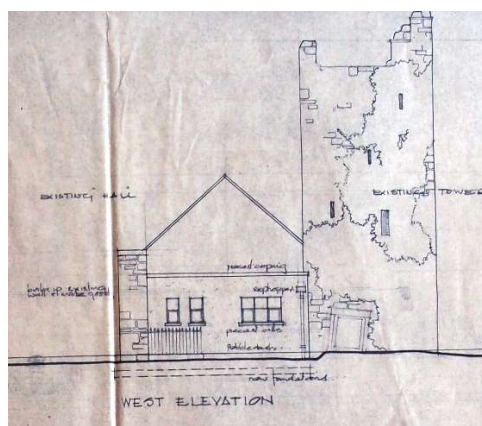
The first of these most important drawings was of O'Flynn Architects dated, 15th May 1979, for the extension to abut the north face of the tower. From the south elevation it is clear the Cotter vault was in the middle of the carpark attached to the remnants of the Abbey wall on the north wall, with a construction note stating, 'build up existing wall & make safe'. With wall was to 'new conc [concrete] capping'.

The west elevation also shows an outline of the Cotter vault in the same location. The construction note against the north face of north wall states, 'build up existing wall & make good,' and on the tower is a feature which could possibly be a doorway into the tower which has partially subsided. It is equally possibly a family vault which has suffered the same fate. The ground level at this point shown to be higher. This elevation proves the then surviving wall was of substantial thickness. As the images of these drawings are not to scale, it is impossible to determine its thickness. It is also sadly noted that this wall no longer exists, and must have been removed during the construction of the extent.

These drawings were in a very poor state, and have been edited and cleaned up to offer more clear images.

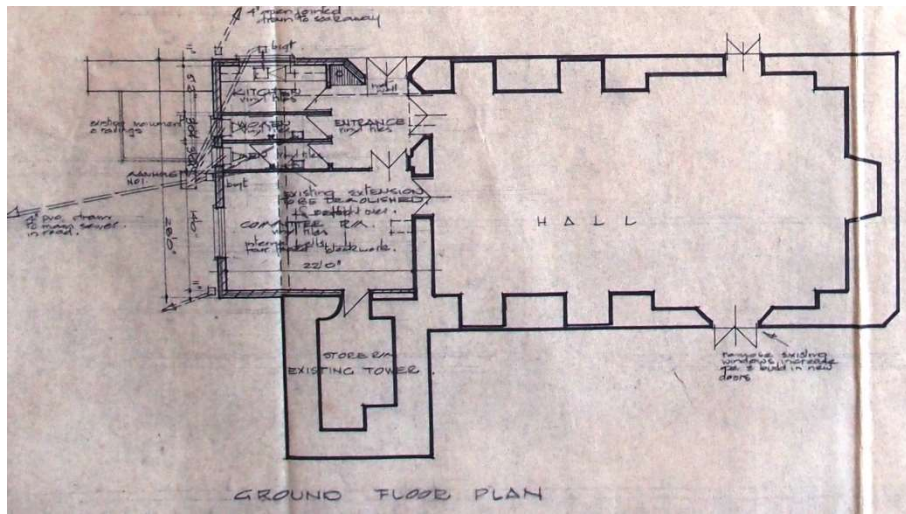


South Elevation of Tower



West Elevation of Tower

From the ground floor plan, it is clear to see the remnants of the Abbey outline forming the 'Hall', and the thickness of these walls which are shown as a shadow line beneath the north elevation of the extension, presumably used as foundations, but there is no comment to that effect on the drawings.



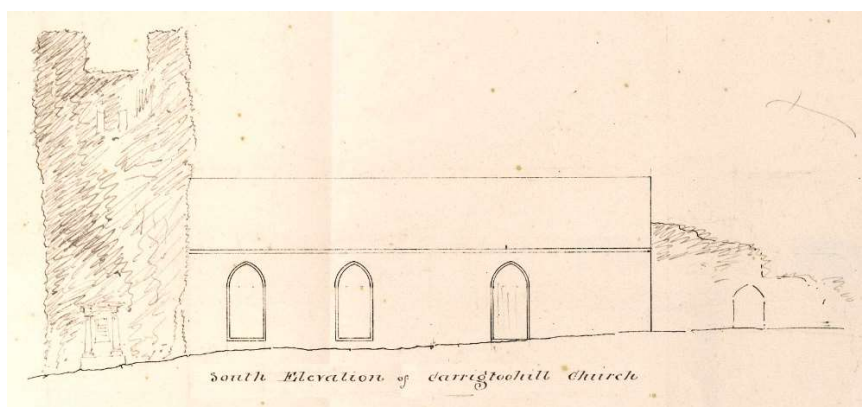
Ground Floor Plan

2.2.2 James Pain 1835 drawings

Brothers James and George Richard Pain were commissioned by the Board of First Fruits to design churches and glebe houses in Ireland. In 1833, James Pain became one of the four principal architects of the Board of Ecclesiastical Commissioners.

Another set of drawing ordered were those by James Pain dated 1835, and gives a slightly different view of the site. These have been similarly edited to produce a cleaner image. Of the church, a few years later, Samuel Lewis' in his publication of 1837 describes it as, 'a small but venerable structure, was repaired and much improved in 1835, by grant of £144.8. from the Ecclesiastical Commissioners.'

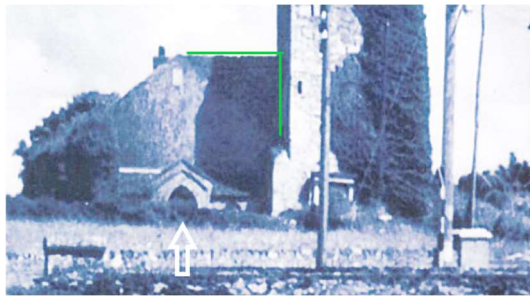
The south elevation appears to indicate a family vault near, or abutting the tower. It also seems to indicate a sloping ground east to west just below the window opes. The rough sketch manner in which the details of the tower and ruins drawn would seemingly indicate that they were of no relevance to the architect. Whereas the church outline is clearly defined. There were no other elevation drawing in this series.



James Pain's South Elevation (1835)

Pain's ground floor plan indicates a wall running northward off the northwest corner of the tower described as in 'ruin' was of the same thickness of the tower walls which is consistent with a recent photograph highlighting this junction as a vertical straight line. It is also consistent with Samuel Lewis' description of the church when he said, '... the chapel is situated on the site of an old abbey near the churchyard, and near it is a parochial house for the priest.' If correct, this must have been the location of Father Horgan's Church which was replaced by Father Seymour's Church.

This wall may have originally been joined with north 'wall of ruin' where Cotter's vault once stood.

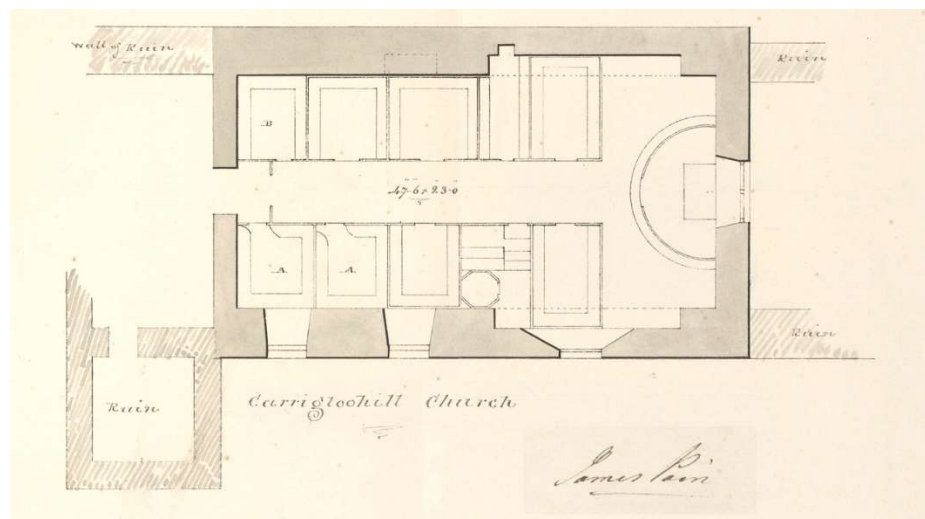


Carrigwohill Through the Centuries

A structure can clearly be seen alongside which has been modified and zoomed into from its original which appeared in the publication, *Carrigwohill Through the Centuries*. The date and source are unknown. There appears to be a peaked doorway in front of a wall and structure seemingly running north-south as seemingly is shown below.

The plan seems to indicate that the church was built on the ruins of the Abbey. At the eastern end it would appear is a window behind the altar which today is filled in.

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James Pain Ground Floor Plan

There is a site plan in the series, but shows nothing of consequence. It does not even indicate the graveyard headstone, so there is no way of knowing the extent of the burial grounds.

Section 3: - Proposed Conservation Works

From the very beginning of the society's formation, concerns were frequently aired in relation to the stability of the Abbey tower, and how best our society may preserve them.

3.1.1 Southgate Associates

Onsite Meeting

Following the successful saving for prosperity Ballyadam Bridge, scheduled for demolition as part of CIE proposal as part of the twin tracking between Glounthaune and Midleton, an enquiry was made to Southgate Associates of South Mall, Cork City; and of Cork Road, Midleton; to seek their assistance to preserve our Abbey ruins who had supported our submission to save this bridge.

The meeting was arranged for 8th August.

Those Present

Carrigtwohill & District Historical Society:

Jim Barry	Chairperson
Frank Hannigan	Committee Member & Team Leader C2H2040
André Saubolle	Secretary & Team Member of C2H2040 Project
Ollie Sheehan	C2H2040 Coordinator <i>(Formerly Chair & Secretary for the Community Council and similarly for the historical society)</i>

Southgate Associates

Chris Southgate	Director & Conservation Engineer
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Site Survey

The party initially met in the carpark from where we proceeded towards the tower at which place preliminary discussions commenced. This immediately began examining the tower construction, paying particular attention to the mortar used which he judged as being of various types, and likely of differing eras. A sample was taken, but Chris explained how the bureaucratic procedure for sample taking for testing may be complicated by serious procedural requirements, and necessary licenses being obtained before being tested in Belfast. Without the mortar test he could only speculate as to its age.

We then continued to walk the perimeter of the remaining structure. Chris was fairly confident that if this was a Monastery, or Abbey, there would be Cloisters attached to it, suggesting the most likely location would be to the north. He then advised that a ground penetrating geophysical radar survey would be able to confirm this, and would determine the full extent of the site.

Chris noted the various construction phases, but was having difficulty understanding the numerous construction methods associated with the Church of Ireland structure built using the Abbey ruin walls as foundations.

Returning to the tower, having studied the various structures, Chris astonished us by declaring it was his considered opinion that tower had originally formed an integral part of the church which we had just been discussing, had collapsed, and the tower we see today was its replacement built circa, 13th century.

The external survey conducted the meeting adjourned to the former St David's Church built in the 1830s, now used as a storeroom for the Church of Ireland Authorities. It was here, when, after his initial survey of the internal structures, and with particular regard to the vaulted ceiling structure that Chris made another astonishing observation which once again took us all totally by surprise, declaring that in his opinion the vaulted ceiling supported a central tower we had just been discussing outside. The material was likely used to build in its new location as the tower we see and love today.

Chris directed our attention to the arches to the north and south wall explaining that it was from these where the transepts would run out of the church. He then outlined his theory in a sketched drawing of what he believed to be the likely shape of the former church the 1830s Church of Ireland incorporated within its own construction.

Mortar Test Results

A preliminary mortar sample from the west elevation of the tower was taken by Chris Southgate for his personal observation and information purposes to be considered in association with other research in the future. Chris explained that mortar samples on their own can contribute to an understanding of the building. However, absolute evidence for dating requires other factors to be taken into account. Carbon dating, which is an expensive process, which in the case of 'Clonmacnoise' for instance has not been totally accepted as sufficiently accurate to challenge the historical record. The scientific analysis (Archaeological Inventory of County Cork. Volume 2: East and South Cork' (Dublin: Stationery Office, 1994)) challenges the historical record of 1128, suggesting this is the 3rd phase of construction.

Chris further explained that the mortars from the central section of the Eastern section of the tower were compared as a preliminary exercise. The mortars were all found to be constructed from an hot lime process considering the presence of lumps of lime in the mix. All the mortars were 'competent and hard' suggesting a good knowledge of building techniques consistent with monastic orders.

Concerning other structures of the site, Chris found it interestingly apparent that the older eastern section appeared to be the mostly constructed of 'competent mortar with fine well prepared mainly limestone aggregate and was surprisingly hard. This showed a high competence of an experienced mortar mason.'



He further explained that the central section (St David's church circa 1830s) differed by the inclusion of Cork Red sandstone. The addition of this rounded aggregate from a riverbed typically 8mm down suggested to him it was of different phase of construction. On the Northern wall of this section, he found that lower and wider course at foundation level had been pointed in sand and cement with no mortar being visible. He confirmed that this course was not visible on the southern

wall, suggesting that this section may have been constructed on an earlier structure.

Lastly the mortars in the tower differ again with a larger rounded Cork Red sandstone composed with river aggregate of a larger grading approx. 20mm down. Chris stressed that 'whilst this kind of analysis does not give exact dating, it can provide (together

with research and other information) useful information to establish for instance when an opening is blocked or altered and other aspects of phasing by comparison.’ He advised that forensic building inspection be undertaken being an iterative process during a research phase, from which much can be gleaned by visual assessment and comparison.

In closing his preliminary report Chris was full of admiration with which enthusiasm and dedication of the society had, declaring it to be ‘inspiring’.

Meeting Conclusion

At the close of the meeting Chris made another intriguing statement. He stated that the Abbey was once a seat of learning and culture, and that it would be fabulous if it could become so again in the heart of the community.

Chris agreed to prepare and submit application on our behalf to the various funding authorities.

3.1.2 Meeting with County Council Heritage Department

Objective

After months of discussions at our regular society committee meetings since our initial meeting with Southgate Associates, a decision was made to seek the assistance and guidance of Cork County Council’s Heritage Department (CCHD) to enquire of best practice they would recommend to safeguard the remaining structures from falling into a further ruinous state, with particular attention being drawn towards the tower which had sustained a recent dislodgement of stonework to the southeastern corner.

Additionally, the stability of the tower belfry was reason for considerable concern, as it is known that the supporting metalwork had begun to rust. Should it fail, it potentially could cause further untold damage to the remaining structure and its stability.

Another objective was to discuss all Government and County Council grant funding options that are available that our society may avail of.

With this in mind an invitation was made to the County Council, which was accepted with an onsite meeting arranged for, 12 noon, 20th June 24.

Those present

Cork County Council Heritage Department:

Annette Quinn	Archaeologist Heritage Department
Elena Turk	Architectural Heritage Officer
Conor Nelligan	Heritage Officer & Commemorations Coordinator

Carrigtwohill & District Historical Society:

Jim Barry	Chairperson
Michael Cummins	Treasurer
André Saubolle	Secretary & team member of C2H2040 Project
Ollie Sheehan	C2H2040 Coordinator

(Formerly Chair & Secretary for the Community Council and similarly for the historical society)

Site Survey

The meeting began with a general survey of the site with particular emphasis made to the recent evidence of stone displacement to the southeastern corner of the tower. There was an additional complication as a recent grave almost abuts this corner. The construction at this corner provides potential evidence of a possible joint at this corner suggesting a wall might extend either eastward, but more likely to the southerly direction.

There is further evidence of stone collapse at the base of the tower to the south face at a former window/doorway at ground level which had been closed in by stonework at some point in its long history.

On the eastern elevation of the tower there is a prolific infestation of ivy which could potentially cause instability to the tower structure, and further irreparable damage.

Discussion then focused on the belfry and the very real fear that the bell would be dislodged from the rusting support and come crashing down, once more, potentially causing irreparable damage.

It was Council's considered recommendation that the Tower with its Belfry be the top priority, with a professional survey of the structure being conducted as a matter of extreme urgency, and must include an ecological assessment. For this survey and subsequent remedial works the County Council would favourably consider an emergency grant to cover this immediate requirement.

It was considered by the Council that a geophysical survey was not a priority at this stage, but would be advantageous at some future date to determine the full extent of the ruins no longer visible above ground which are known to extend westward beneath the gravelled carpark.

It was mentioned that there was a proposal to develop the location at the current tennis court which came as a surprise to the Council representatives. We (CDHS) were informed that as part of any planning application the applicant must conduct a geophysical survey to be included in their application.

We were advised that under no circumstances can any work be undertaken without the expressed approval of the Heritage Department. To do so would be a criminal offence as it is already a protected structure listed in the County Council's Development Plan, 2024-28.

The meeting then moved into the former St David's Church, where the Council representatives were astonished to see the remains of a vaulted ceiling designed to hold in place a substantial structure that Chris Southgate had also previously observed.

Plan of Action

It was strongly recommended that we (CDHS) prepare a detailed plan of action, placing in order the priority of each proposal. It was further recommended that the highest priority be given to the undertaking of a survey of the tower, and the immediate remedial works required as discussed during site meeting.

Official Grant Aid

Another of our (CDHS) concerns was the nature of official funding government agencies and the County Council would offer, and how we could best avail of them.

These include the:

In a follow-up email from Conor Nelligan (CCC) regarding our meeting on 24th June 2024, he confirmed that there are a few potential avenues for funding, ‘given the rich archaeological heritage on site and that the tower’, legally protected as ‘RPS ID No. 854’. In relation to the latter, being the tower, he advised that there are currently two key schemes; the Built Heritage Investment Scheme, and the Historic Structures Fund. These schemes are both operated by Elena Turk and her colleague Emma Baume, at the Heritage Department. Applications for this year’s schemes closed in mid-January.

Emma had previously supported our application to save Ballyadam Bridge during the An Bord Pleanála public consultation process of the twin tracking between Glounthaune and Midleton.

Regarding the Community Monuments Fund, it is anticipated that applications will be accepted again towards the end of this year.

“In regard to the 2024 application, and as noted, it was a good proposal, and while it scored higher than some of the other proposals received under Stream 2, it did not score as highly as the two applications put forward. When reapplying, consider an application under Stream 2 and Stream 3 as discussed and be sure to strongly emphasise the urgency of the works, and how the project is of such importance to the community. The holding of a Heritage Week event on site this year, or regarding the site, could also be of benefit and could be referenced in any further application.

Other potential avenues of funding, particularly for the Geophysics side of things, include the Heritage Council’s Community Grant Scheme and Cork County Council’s County Cork Heritage Grant Scheme – these typically open in February/March each year.”

During the site meeting Conor acknowledged that official funding streams could not fully support the anticipated or unforeseen costs of the proposed conservation works. Therefore, would encourage all efforts to seek additional funding from alternative sources, and complemented the fundraising efforts already such as the GoFundMe campaign which he endorsed.